

Stay human

A lot of people make the mistake of thinking that technology is just computer-related stuff – lines of code, hardware, software, that sort of thing. Sure, that's the area we think about today, and perhaps even for the past two decades, but the truth is the entire human history has been technology driven.

From cavemen who discovered flint, or the ability to hunt better using pointy sticks and rocks, to the invention of the wheel, and then onwards through history till today – what really drove the invention craze?

They say necessity is the mother of invention, but is it really that simple? Why has technology (used loosely, again) become the driving factor of our entire species?

There's something to be said about simplification of tasks. We look at the end result, and assume that technology's job is to help us reach said result as quickly as possible. Efficiency is the key.

Then again, maybe it's just to do away with the mundane. None of us really wants to pull out logarithmic tables to do complicated calculations, carrying the remainder in our heads.

Perhaps it's laziness? Do we want motorised transport because we're too lazy to walk, spell checkers because we're too lazy to learn to spell, gaming because we're too lazy to go outside and exert?

Einstein wasn't lazy, but he'd have a hard time coming up with Relativity in his lifetime if he had to invent mathematics and physics as well. If everyone starts at the same point, how much further can anyone get? Imagine having to build a house to live in everyday...would you ever really have time to perfect the plumbing?

I think technology is more like a cure to this indescribable and unbearable itch. Maybe it's a mix of all of the above and more, or perhaps it's just the next stage of our evolution – a way of extending our brains, and ourselves.

We need technology to get us the information we need, when we need it. Over the years, it has blended seamlessly into our psyche, and there are hundreds of tasks that we do everyday that we just don't think about anymore – making a simple phone call, answering an email, video chatting with someone from across the globe, paying bills, automating tasks, finding information... In

a million and more ways, we do such a lot whilst on auto-pilot mode.

Automating tasks, and not thinking about them is one thing, but as much as technology has mind-melded with us like a Vulcan to make us all powerful, perhaps we're also being assimilated like the victims of the Borg! No, I'm not a doomsday soothsayer trying to warn the world of a coming apocalypse at the hands of technology – what I'm trying to say is, perhaps we're losing a little too much of our humanness in the process.

One look at the majority of the likes, shares and re-tweets in the social world will tell you that way too much of it is just brainless clicking. We send email forwards mercilessly, and murder all languages with lazy slang. We troll, we watch pornography, download pirated content, phish for money, etc.

All of this is part and parcel of the same human condition that has been boosted using technology. Then again, so is Wikipedia, Khan Academy, open source and a million more good things.

It's important that we realise that technology can help us speed anything up, or bypass a million things, but it doesn't need to do that for everything. Some things need a human touch.

Although it can and will make our lives easier (or worse), it cannot start thinking for us – it's why Google's search suggestions are bang on target at times, and can make you wonder what the Google bot's been smoking at others.

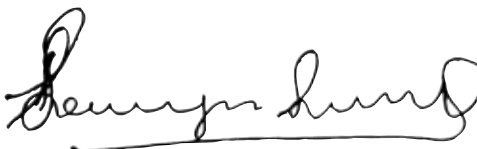
The real goal of this cover story – and this magazine, in fact – is to encourage us to use technology as a stepping stone instead of as a crutch – attempting to discover new and unique ways of using technology to enhance the human experience.

If we really want to advance and evolve, we have to realise when to let out the technology-enabled automaton inside us, and when to stay human. 



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“Imagine having to build a house to live in everyday...would you ever really have time to perfect the plumbing?”

A handwritten signature in black ink, which appears to read 'Robert Sovereign-Smith'.

Liked or hated this column?
Write in to editor@thinkdigit.com and let me know your thoughts.